

# » 2025 PROGRAM REPORT



**Low Income  
Taxpayer Clinics**  
REPRESENTATION • EDUCATION • ADVOCACY



# Low Income Taxpayer Clinics

REPRESENTATION • EDUCATION • ADVOCACY

## OUR MISSION

Low Income Taxpayer Clinics (LITCs) ensure the fairness and integrity of the tax system for taxpayers who are low-income or speak English as a second language by:

- ♦ Providing *pro bono* representation on their behalf in tax disputes with the IRS;
- ♦ Educating them about their rights and responsibilities as taxpayers; and
- ♦ Identifying and advocating for issues that impact these taxpayers.

## ABOUT THE PROGRAM

The LITC Program is a federal grant program that provides up to \$100,000 per year to qualifying organizations. For grant years 2023 and 2024, the maximum grant amount was increased to \$200,000. The program unites a nationwide network of independent organizations under a shared mission to protect taxpayer rights. The LITC Program Office is part of the Office of the Taxpayer Advocate.

[www.TaxpayerAdvocate.irs.gov/LITC](http://www.TaxpayerAdvocate.irs.gov/LITC)



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# LETTER FROM THE NATIONAL TAXPAYER ADVOCATE

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Dear Reader:

I am pleased to present the Low Income Taxpayer Clinic Program Report highlighting the important work carried out during the 2024 grant year (January 1 to December 31, 2024) and to express my sincere appreciation to the dedicated Low Income Taxpayer Clinic (LITC) practitioners, students, and volunteers at legal aid organizations, academic institutions, and nonprofit organizations across the country whose commitment makes this work possible.

In 2024, many taxpayers continued to face significant challenges obtaining timely assistance with tax-related issues. As IRS resources remained strained, low-income and vulnerable taxpayers were often left without the help they needed to resolve complex problems. Once again, the LITCs stepped up to fill this critical gap, working tirelessly, adapting to evolving needs, and thinking outside the box to develop creative solutions to ensure no taxpayer was left behind. The data and stories in this report reflect the real and lasting difference LITC practitioners and volunteers made in the lives of individuals and families nationwide.

The LITC grant program is more than a source of funding. It represents a vibrant, mission-driven community of dedicated practitioners and hundreds of volunteers who expand the reach of the clinics far beyond what any single organization could achieve alone. As I applaud the work of the LITCs, I encourage readers to consider how they, too, might support this vital effort, whether by volunteering time, sharing expertise, or providing other forms of assistance.

By taking on even one case through the LITC Program, you can make a tangible difference in the life of a taxpayer who is struggling to navigate the tax system alone. Clinics across the country need your help. You can find an LITC near you and learn more about opportunities to get involved by visiting the TAS website at [www.TaxpayerAdvocate.irs.gov](http://www.TaxpayerAdvocate.irs.gov). If you are unable to volunteer your time directly, consider supporting the program by adopting a clinic at [www.taxpayeradvocate.irs.gov/about-us/litc-grants/adopt-an-litc/](http://www.taxpayeradvocate.irs.gov/about-us/litc-grants/adopt-an-litc/) or contributing in other meaningful ways. The impact you can have on an individual or a family facing tax challenges is immeasurable, and the rewards are priceless.

Thank you to everyone who contributed to the success of the 2024 grant year. My team and I look forward to another successful year as we continue to work together to ensure a fair, accessible, and just tax system for all.

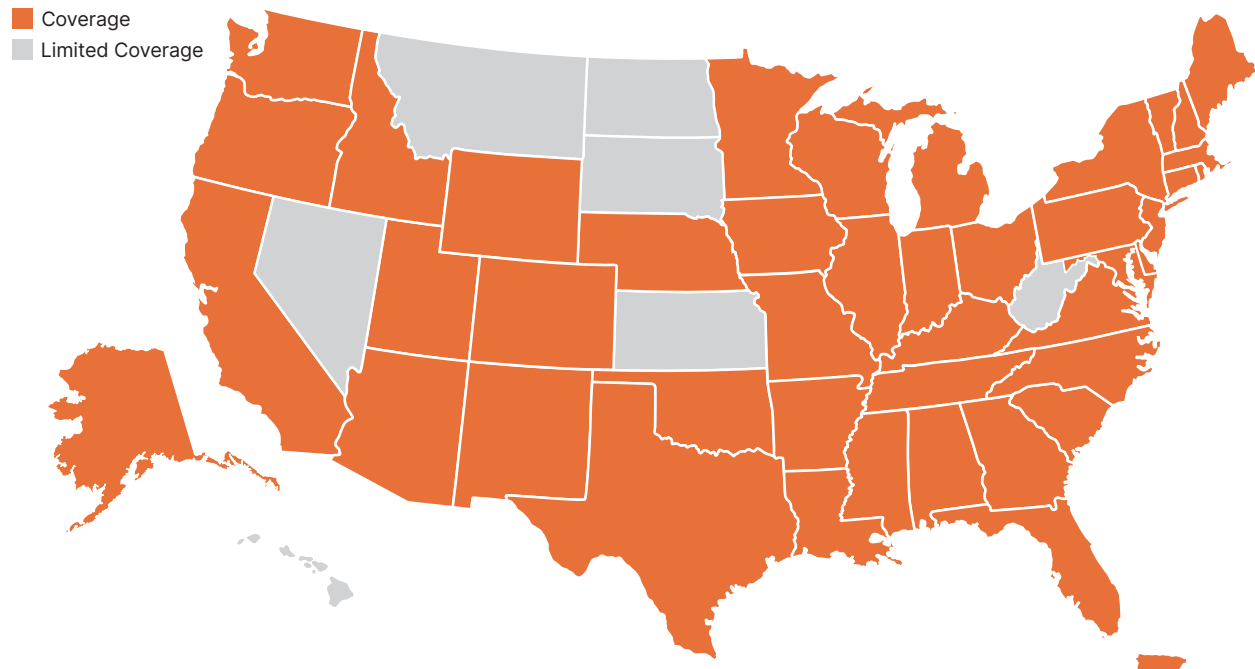
Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, which appears to read "Erin M. Collins". The signature is fluid and cursive.

**Erin M. Collins**

*National Taxpayer Advocate*

# LITC LOCATIONS: GRANT YEAR 2024



## ALABAMA

- **Montgomery**  
Legal Services Alabama LITC

## ALASKA

- **Anchorage**  
Alaska Business Development Center LITC

## ARIZONA

- **Flagstaff**  
DNA People's Legal Services LITC
- **Phoenix**  
Community Legal Services LITC
- **Tucson**  
Southern Arizona Tax Clinic

## ARKANSAS

- **Little Rock**  
UA Little Rock Bowen School of Law LITC
- **Springdale**  
Legal Aid of Arkansas LITC

## CALIFORNIA

- **Granada Hills**  
Taxpayer Help Center
- **Los Angeles**  
Bet Tzedek Legal Services Tax Clinic  
KYCC Low Income Taxpayer Clinic  
Pepperdine LITC  
Bookstein Low Income Taxpayer Clinic
- **Orange**  
Chapman University Tax Law Clinic

- **Riverside**  
Inland Counties Legal Services LITC
- **San Diego**  
Legal Aid Society of San Diego LITC  
University of San Diego LITC
- **San Francisco**  
Chinese Newcomers Service Center  
Justice and Diversity Center of the Bar Association of San Francisco  
UC Law San Francisco LITC
- **San Luis Obispo**  
Cal Poly Low Income Taxpayer Clinic
- **Santa Ana**  
Public Law Center

## COLORADO

- **Denver**  
Colorado Legal Services LITC  
Denver Asset Building Coalition LITC  
University of Denver LITC

## CONNECTICUT

- **Hamden**  
Quinnipiac University School of Law LITC
- **Hartford**  
UConn Law School Tax Clinic

## DELAWARE

- **Georgetown**  
DCRAC LITC

## DISTRICT OF COLUMBIA

- **Washington**  
LITC Support Center  
American University Washington College of Law, Janet R. Spragens Tax Clinic

## FLORIDA

- **Ft. Myers**  
Florida Rural Legal Services Low Income Taxpayer Clinic
- **Gainesville**  
University of Florida Levin College of Law LITC
- **Miami**  
Legal Services of Greater Miami Community Tax Clinic
- **Plant City**  
Bay Area Legal Services Inc. LITC
- **Plantation**  
Legal Aid Services of Broward and Collier Counties
- **St. Petersburg**  
Gulfcoast Legal Services LITC
- **Tallahassee**  
Legal Services of North Florida
- **West Palm Beach**  
Legal Aid Society of Palm Beach County LITC

## GEORGIA

- **Atlanta**  
The Philip C. Cook Low Income Taxpayer Clinic  
Operation Hope
- **Hinesville**  
JCVison and Associates, Inc.

- **Lawrenceville**  
North Georgia Low Income Taxpayer Clinic

## IDAHO

- **Boise**  
University of Idaho LITC
- **Twin Falls**  
La Posada Tax Clinic

## ILLINOIS

- **Chicago**  
Ladder Up Tax Clinic  
Legal Aid Chicago LITC
- **Des Plaines**  
Center of Concern
- **Wheaton**  
Prairie State Legal Services LITC

## INDIANA

- **Bloomington**  
Indiana Legal Services, Inc. LITC
- **Indianapolis**  
Neighborhood Christian Legal Clinic

## IOWA

- **Des Moines**  
Iowa Legal Aid LITC

## KENTUCKY

- **Covington**  
Legal Aid of the Bluegrass LITC
- **Louisville**  
Legal Aid Society Low Income Taxpayer Clinic
- **Richmond**  
AppalRed Low Income Taxpayer Clinic

## LOUISIANA

- **Baton Rouge**  
Louisiana State University Law LITC
- **New Orleans**  
Southeast Louisiana Legal Services LITC

## MAINE

- **Bangor**  
Pine Tree Legal Assistance Inc. LITC

## MARYLAND

- **Baltimore**  
Maryland Volunteer Lawyers Service LITC  
University of Baltimore LITC  
University of Maryland Carey School of Law LITC

## MASSACHUSETTS

- **Boston**  
AACA LITC  
Greater Boston Legal Services LITC
- **Jamaica Plain**  
Legal Services Center of Harvard Law School LITC
- **Lawrence**  
Northeast Legal Aid LITC

## MICHIGAN

- **Ann Arbor**  
University of Michigan LITC
- **Detroit**  
Accounting Aid Society
- **East Lansing**  
Alvin L. Storrs Low Income Taxpayer Clinic
- **Grand Rapids**  
West Michigan Low Income Taxpayer Clinic (Legal Aid of Western Michigan)

## MINNESOTA

- **Minneapolis**  
Mid-Minnesota Legal Aid Tax Law Project  
University of Minnesota LITC

## MISSISSIPPI

- **Gautier**  
Southern Mississippi Tax Volunteers
- **Oxford**  
Mississippi Taxpayer Assistance Project

## MISSOURI

- **Kansas City**  
Legal Aid of Western Missouri LITC  
UMKC School of Law LITC
- **St. Louis**  
Washington University School of Law LITC

## NEBRASKA

- **Lincoln**  
Legal Aid of Nebraska LITC

## NEW HAMPSHIRE

- **Concord**  
603 Legal Aid Low Income Taxpayer Project

## NEW JERSEY

- **Atlantic City**  
South Jersey Legal Services, Inc. LITC
- **Edison**  
Legal Services of New Jersey Tax Legal Assistance Project
- **Hamilton**  
United Way of Mercer County
- **Jersey City**  
Northeast New Jersey Legal Services LITC
- **Newark**  
Rutgers Federal Tax Law Clinic

## NEW MEXICO

- **Albuquerque**  
New Mexico Legal Aid Low Income Taxpayer Clinic

## NEW YORK

- **Albany**  
Legal Aid Society of Northeastern New York LITC
- **Bronx**  
Bronx Legal Services
- **Brooklyn**  
Brooklyn Legal Services Corporation A LITC  
Brooklyn Low-Income Taxpayer Clinic
- **Buffalo**  
Erie County Bar Association Volunteer Lawyers Project LITC
- **Jamaica**  
Queens Legal Services LITC
- **New York**  
Fordham Law School Mobilization for Justice The Legal Aid Society LITC
- **Rochester**  
Empire Justice Center LITC
- **Syracuse**  
Syracuse University College of Law LITC

## NORTH CAROLINA

- **Asheville**  
Pisgah Legal Services LITC
- **Charlotte**  
North Carolina Low Income Taxpayer Clinic

## OHIO

- **Akron**  
Community Legal Aid Services LITC
- **Cincinnati**  
Legal Aid of Greater Cincinnati LITC
- **Cleveland**  
The Legal Aid Society of Cleveland LITC
- **Columbus**  
Legal Aid of Southeast and Central Ohio LITC
- **Toledo**  
Toledo Tax Controversy Clinic

## OKLAHOMA

- **Tulsa**  
Legal Aid Services of Oklahoma LITC

## OREGON

- **Portland**  
Legal Aid Services of Oregon LITC  
Lewis & Clark Low Income Taxpayer Clinic  
Oregon Law Center LITC

## PENNSYLVANIA

- **Dallas**  
Misericordia University LITC
- **Philadelphia**  
Philadelphia Legal Assistance Taxpayer Support Clinic  
Temple Law School LITC
- **Pittsburgh**  
University of Pittsburgh School of Law LITC
- **Villanova**  
Villanova Federal Tax Clinic
- **Washington**  
Southwestern Pennsylvania Legal Services LITC
- **Williamsport**  
Susquehanna Legal Aid for Adults and Youth
- **York**  
MidPenn Legal Services Low Income Taxpayer Clinic

## PUERTO RICO

- **San Juan**  
Puerto Rico Tax Foundation

## RHODE ISLAND

- **Providence**  
Rhode Island Legal Services LITC

## SOUTH CAROLINA

- **Columbia**  
USC School of Law Low Income Tax Clinic
- **Greenville**  
South Carolina Legal Services LITC

## TENNESSEE

- **Memphis**  
Memphis Area Legal Services
- **Nashville**  
Tennessee Taxpayer Project

## TEXAS

- **Fort Worth**  
Legal Aid of Northwest Texas LITC  
Texas A&M University School of Law, Tax Dispute Resolution Clinic
- **Houston**  
Houston Volunteer Lawyers LITC  
Lone Star Legal Aid LITC  
South Texas College of Law LITC
- **Lubbock**  
Texas Tech School of Law LITC
- **San Antonio**  
Texas Taxpayer Assistance Project

## UTAH

- **Orem**  
Utah Tax Help Services
- **Provo**  
Centro Hispano LITC
- **Salt Lake City**  
Westminster Tax Clinic

## VERMONT

- **Burlington**  
Vermont Low Income Taxpayer Clinic

## VIRGINIA

- **Fairfax**  
Legal Services of Northern Virginia LITC
- **Lexington**  
Washington and Lee University School of Law Tax Clinic
- **Richmond**  
The Community Tax Law Project

## WASHINGTON

- **Seattle**  
University of Washington Federal Tax Clinic
- **Spokane**  
Gonzaga University Federal Tax Clinic

## WISCONSIN

- **Milwaukee**  
Legal Action of Wisconsin LITC

## WYOMING

- **Laramie**  
University of Wyoming LITC

*Note: States shown as limited coverage do not have an LITC physically located in the state. Taxpayers may be served by LITCs located in other states.*



Scan to view the most up-to-date  
clinic information.

[www.TaxpayerAdvocate.irs.gov/LITC](http://www.TaxpayerAdvocate.irs.gov/LITC)





## REPRESENTATION • EDUCATION • ADVOCACY

In 2024, the Low Income Taxpayer Clinic (LITC) Program provided matching grants of up to \$200,000\* to qualifying organizations to operate a low-income taxpayer clinic. LITCs provide service to low-income and English as a second language (ESL) taxpayers. Services are provided for free or a nominal fee.

*\*For the past three grant years, Congress has authorized funding of up to \$200,000 per clinic.*

### How do LITCs help low-income taxpayers?



Represent low-income individuals in disputes with the IRS and state tax agencies and help taxpayers:

- Achieve better outcomes in cases
- Access benefits administered through the tax code
- Resolve tax debts, levies, and liens
- Litigate cases in U.S. Tax Court and other federal courts



### EDUCATE

Educate ESL and low-income taxpayers about their rights and responsibilities and help them:

- Understand the U.S. tax system
- Exercise their rights as taxpayers
- Comply with their responsibilities as taxpayers



### ADVOCATE

Advocate for low-income and ESL taxpayers about relevant issues that impact them and help the IRS:

- Identify and fix problems with the tax system
- Ensure the fairness and integrity of the tax system for all taxpayers

*Performance data from 2024 LITC Year-End Report, GrantSolutions.*

LITCs are located across the country at locations such as:

- ▶ Legal aid organizations
- ▶ Law, business, or accounting schools
- ▶ Other not-for-profit organizations

In 2024, we delivered the following results for taxpayers and their families:

**21,180**

Taxpayers represented

**2,774**

Taxpayers brought into filing compliance

**18,546**

Taxpayers provided consultation or advice

**3,186**

Taxpayers brought into collection compliance

**Over \$10 million**

Refunds secured for low-income taxpayers



**Over \$53 million**

Liabilities decreased or corrected



**1,370** Volunteers

**45,019** Volunteer hours

**20,517\*** Educational activities



**161,812\*** Attendees at educational activities

*\*Includes activities (and attendees) conducted by ESL Education Program clinics such as federal tax-related financial wellness coaching sessions and online learning.*

# INTRODUCTION

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This Program Report highlights the critical work that the 137 funded LITCs undertook during 2024. This number includes ten first-time grant recipients. LITCs serve taxpayers who often face significant financial, language, or educational barriers when interacting with the tax system. The work of the clinics is best illustrated through the real-world stories of individuals and families whose lives LITCs helped stabilize through representation, education, and advocacy.<sup>1</sup> Before delving into these compelling examples, this report provides an overview and context for readers less familiar with the essential role LITCs play in supporting both individual taxpayers and effective tax administration.



# PROGRAM OVERVIEW

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The LITC Program was established under IRC § 7526 as part of the IRS Restructuring and Reform Act of 1998<sup>2</sup> and remains a cornerstone of tax justice emerging from that key tax legislation. Under the statute, the IRS is authorized to award eligible low-income taxpayer clinics up to \$100,000 per year with a dollar-for-dollar matching requirement.<sup>3</sup> Each grant, therefore, represents a financial partnership between the federal government and community-based organizations committed to serving taxpayers in need. The matching funds investment, when teamed with the federal funding, allows LITCs to grow, reach more taxpayers, and provide services that would otherwise be unavailable.

For fiscal years (FYs) 2023 and 2024, Congress demonstrated its ongoing commitment to strengthening the program by increasing overall funding and maintaining the increased cap at \$200,000 per clinic.<sup>4</sup> This support continued into FY 2025 and allowed clinics to broaden their reach and services.

Despite these advancements and increased congressional support, challenges remain. The National Taxpayer Advocate's 2025 Purple Book recommends a critical next step – amending IRC § 7526 to remove the per-clinic funding cap and reduce the match requirement to 25%. Removing the per-clinic cap would provide TAS flexibility in allocating appropriated funds between clinics but would not impact the total annual appropriated funds. This change would preserve that crucial shared investment while reducing barriers that prevent some organizations from applying for or continuing participation in the program. This permanent solution would better enable the LITC Program to expand its reach and provide comprehensive assistance to eligible taxpayers in communities across the United States.<sup>5</sup>

## A Unifying Mission

When Congress enacted IRC § 7526, it recognized that achieving a correct outcome in an IRS dispute should not be dependent on an individual's ability to pay for representation. Congress also acknowledged that taxpayers with limited English proficiency often face additional challenges navigating tax compliance and enforcement. For these reasons, Congress authorized funding for organizations to provide both representation and education services. Clinics offering these services are uniquely positioned to identify, evaluate, and advocate for taxpayers where the IRS's interpretation and implementation of the tax laws harm taxpayers or hinder them from exercising their rights. Encouraging clinics to identify systemic problems and propose solutions benefits not only taxpayers but also tax administration by helping the IRS shape policies to better serve taxpayers and more fairly administer tax laws.

Access to free or low-cost representation is essential to upholding taxpayer rights. Providing low-income taxpayers with access to free or low-cost tax advocacy, whether in a controversy with the IRS or through an educational program, serves important public policies. Representation helps ensure that taxpayers obtain fair results within the tax system and that tax administration becomes more responsive to the needs of all taxpayers, regardless of income level. Education, particularly for English as a second language (ESL) taxpayers about their tax reporting and payment obligations, promotes understanding of the tax obligations and enables tax compliance, the cornerstone of the U.S. tax system.

## Low Income Taxpayer Clinics Play an Important Role in Protecting Taxpayer Rights

The Taxpayer Bill of Rights (TBOR) is a fundamental framework that empowers taxpayers by consolidating their rights into a clear and accessible document. Adopted by the IRS in June 2014 and later codified by Congress in IRC § 7803(a)(3) in 2015, TBOR ensures that taxpayers are aware of their rights when interacting with the IRS. Among the ten fundamental rights is the taxpayer *right to retain representation*, a right that LITCs are instrumental in protecting and promoting.<sup>6</sup>

Access to a knowledgeable representative who understands the complexities of the tax code and IRS procedures empowers low-income taxpayers to also exercise other rights, including the taxpayer *rights to pay no more than the correct amount of tax, to challenge the IRS's position and be heard, and to appeal an IRS decision in an independent forum*.<sup>7</sup> LITCs rely on TBOR in their advocacy efforts, identifying violations and seeking fair treatment of taxpayers both administratively and in court proceedings.

Beyond representation, LITCs play an important role in ensuring both low-income and ESL taxpayers are well informed about their rights and responsibilities. Through education provided to taxpayers and community partners, LITCs promote the taxpayer *right to be informed*.<sup>8</sup> Additionally, LITCs help advocate for the taxpayer *right to a fair and just tax system*,<sup>9</sup> elevating systemic issues to the IRS or TAS when they have the potential to harm taxpayers or interfere with their rights.

To improve the efficiency and effectiveness of the LTC program, IRS employees can refer a taxpayer to one or more LITCs.<sup>10</sup> Volunteer Income Tax Assistance (VITA)<sup>11</sup> grant recipients are also encouraged to inform taxpayers about the availability of LITCs.<sup>12</sup> LITCs are encouraged to refer taxpayers for current year tax preparation to VITA and Tax Counseling for the Elderly (TCE) sites.

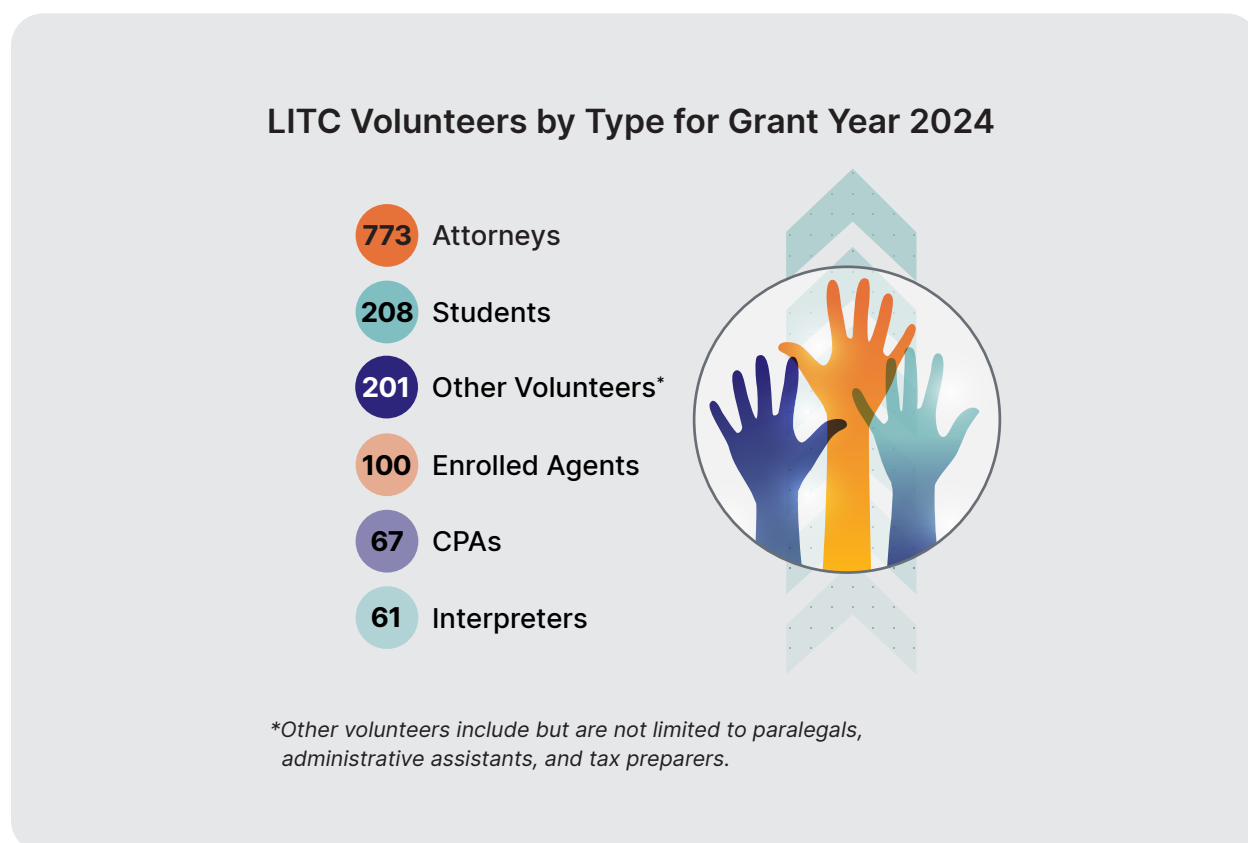
The LTC Program Office, in collaboration with the IRS Stakeholder Partnerships, Education, and Communication office, hosts an annual summit to strengthen partnerships, foster new collaborations, and share best practices to ensure taxpayers receive holistic support and avoid duplication of efforts. An annual online summit helps to highlight the value of these partnerships, inform new grantees about these opportunities, and continue to identify new and promising practices. The 2024 grant year marked the second summit; the third will occur in 2026.

## Volunteers Help Expand Low Income Taxpayer Clinic Reach

Volunteers play a vital role in expanding the reach and impact of LITCs. Clinics are strongly encouraged to develop and maintain a panel of volunteers, which allows them to serve more taxpayers and provide a broader range of services. Each LTC must have a staff member or a volunteer admitted to practice before the U.S. Tax Court and other federal courts to represent taxpayers in litigation matters. LITCs may also partner with and make referrals to *pro bono* panels operated by state and local bar associations or other professional organizations.

Volunteer opportunities extend far beyond direct representation. Volunteers assist clinics in essential ways, including researching tax law, organizing case files, translating written materials, interpreting at outreach and education events, providing clerical support, and assisting with website development and maintenance. By leveraging volunteer support, clinics expand their reach to enhance the services they offer and maximize available resources.

FIGURE 1





## **Pro Bono Volunteers Help Secure Needed Stimulus Payments**

In May 2024, Professor Amy Spivey of the College of the Law San Francisco LITC organized an in-person clinic to assist taxpayers who had not yet received their 2020 stimulus payments. Hosted in San Francisco's Tenderloin neighborhood, the in-person clinic partnered with a nonprofit organization whose staff canvassed the area and helped spread the word to residents most in need. LITC volunteers staffed the clinic and helped over 50 taxpayers, many of whom faced barriers to accessing prior year refunds. Volunteers helped taxpayers understand how to prepare past due tax returns and initiate refund traces. TAS employees were also available to review taxpayer accounts and obtain transcripts, allowing volunteers to best advise the taxpayers. Through strong collaboration and on-the-ground community outreach, the clinic successfully connected underserved taxpayers with the support they needed to access long overdue stimulus funds, a resource that made a meaningful difference in their financial stability.

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In 2024, over 1,300 volunteers provided more than 45,000 hours of service to the LITCs across the country, highlighting the critical role that tax professionals and volunteers play in strengthening taxpayer advocacy and access to justice. Their efforts are meaningful and lasting and key to the overall success of the LITC Program.



## **Volunteer Spotlight**

Attorney Jim Meadows is one of the many volunteers who donate their time and expertise to improve outcomes for taxpayers facing IRS controversies. He joined Build Up Justice NYC as a *pro bono* volunteer following a successful decades-long career at various law firms. Through his work with LITC, Meadows has made an enormous impact for New Yorkers navigating complex tax disputes. He provides *pro bono* representation to low-income taxpayers in disputes with the IRS, assists taxpayers with preparing returns to resolve controversies, presents at educational events, and mentors LITC team staff and volunteers.

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If Meadows' commitment to volunteerism inspires you, find a clinic using the locator tool at [www.TaxpayerAdvocate.irs.gov/LITC](https://www.TaxpayerAdvocate.irs.gov/LITC) or by reading Publication 4134, Low Income Taxpayer Clinic List, at <https://www.irs.gov/pub/irs-pdf/p4134.pdf>. Clinics welcome support in many forms, and even a modest contribution of time, money, or expertise can make a meaningful difference in your community.

# LITCs REPRESENT TAXPAYERS

## Access to Representation Matters

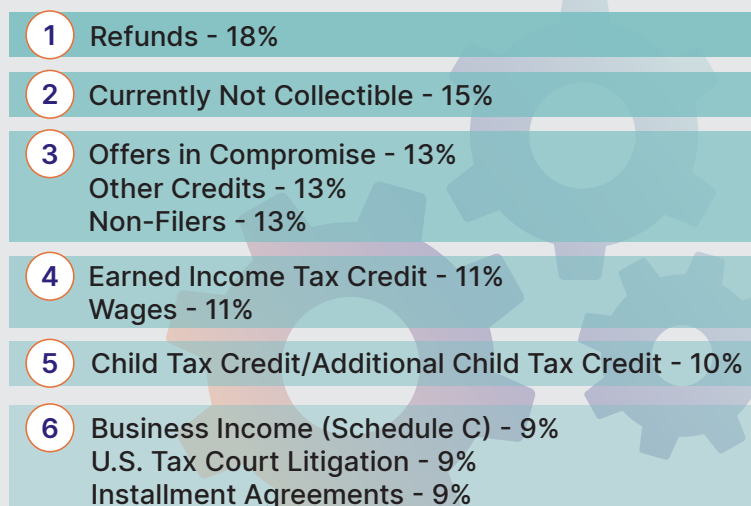
The tax code is complex, and resolving a tax controversy often requires navigating challenging administrative processes. Taxpayers who have representation during the process are more likely to stay engaged and reach a successful result. A knowledgeable tax professional understands how to interpret the law, communicate effectively with the IRS, and identify the most appropriate resolution options.

In 2024, LITCs represented 21,180 taxpayers facing IRS tax controversies. A controversy includes any dispute between an individual and the IRS concerning the determination, collection, or refund of any tax, penalty, or interest. The definition of a controversy is broad and encompasses all disputes arising under the Internal Revenue Code except for criminal tax matters. Controversies include math error notices, denial of refund claims, collection actions, examinations, litigation, or pursuit of other relief where the IRS is the other party involved.<sup>13</sup> LITC assistance with a federal tax controversy may also extend to addressing a related state or local tax issue. For example, an audit finding at the federal level can cause an assessment of state or local tax. Removing the federal assessment without addressing the state or local assessment may leave the taxpayer carrying the burden of unresolved tax debt, so LITCs may help with both.

Figure 2 shows the most frequently worked issues in 2024, with percentages based on the number of cases worked with a particular issue as compared to the total cases worked. Most LITC cases involve collection, refund, and status issues. Because cases often involve multiple issues and require interaction with more than one IRS function, access to experienced representation is especially critical for low-income taxpayers who cannot afford paid legal representation.

FIGURE 2

### Most Frequently Worked Issues in Grant Year 2024



## Collection Issues

Approximately 34% of taxpayers represented by LITCs in 2024 sought help with IRS collection issues. The collection process typically starts when the IRS issues a balance due notice, which allows a taxpayer to challenge the amount owed, seek alternative payment agreements, or negotiate a collection alternative.

For many taxpayers, communicating with the IRS and understanding available options can be overwhelming. IRS notices may be confusing, response times can be short, wait times can be long, and taxpayers who are facing financial hardship may feel pressured to enter into a payment agreement they will be unable to maintain. Many LTC cases involve taxpayers who cannot afford to both pay their IRS debt and basic living expenses. Meanwhile, penalties and interest continue to accrue, increasing the burden.

In 2024, LITCs assisted over 7,100 taxpayers facing IRS collection actions, helping them regain financial stability and move forward with their lives free from the burden of unresolved tax debt. Some of the options available include:

- ◆ Currently not collectible status, which suspends collection activity when the taxpayer cannot pay after covering basic living expenses;
- ◆ Installment agreements (or payment plans), which allow the taxpayer to pay a tax debt over time; and
- ◆ Offers in compromise (OICs), which allow a taxpayer to satisfy a tax debt for less than the full amount because they cannot afford to full pay.



### **Academic Low Income Taxpayer Clinic Helps Taxpayer Obtain an Offer in Compromise**

Students at an academic LTC assisted a senior taxpayer with resolving nearly \$20,000 in federal tax debt. The taxpayer had multiple health issues and had to take medical leave from a part-time job, which forced the taxpayer to rely solely on limited Social Security benefits. The clinic submitted an OIC on the taxpayer's behalf, but the IRS initially rejected it. The IRS proposed that the taxpayer liquidate a modest retirement account to satisfy the debt. The LTC appealed the decision arguing that requiring liquidation would be unreasonable given the taxpayer's age, medical conditions, and financial hardship. The appeal was successful, and the IRS accepted a small lump sum payment to resolve the debt. A month later, however, the taxpayer received a Notice of Federal Tax Lien for the debt resolved with the OIC. The LTC jumped in to help again, and the IRS agreed to release the lien. When the case was finally resolved, the taxpayer expressed gratitude for the students' advocacy, noting the relief of having the burden lifted during a challenging period of life.



## Refunds and Reducing Liabilities

Refund issues are a common challenge faced by low-income taxpayers, particularly when the IRS reviews a tax return and disallows expenses, deductions, or credits. Those actions may significantly reduce a taxpayer's refund or result in an unexpected tax due. For many households, refunds represent a critical source of income used to pay rent, utilities, medical expenses, or childcare. In 2024, over 17% of cases worked by LITCs involved refund issues. Through their advocacy, LITCs secured over \$10.9 million in refunds for taxpayers. These refunds are critical to financial stability and often represent a significant portion of annual income for lower-income households.

Among the credits often disallowed by the IRS are the Earned Income Tax Credit and the Child Tax Credit. These credits are vital lifelines for low-income families, helping to lift them out of poverty and providing critical stability that children need. When the tax returns claiming these credits are audited or denied, the financial impact can be devastating.



### Low Income Taxpayer Clinic Helps Taxpayer Obtain Much-Needed Earned Income Tax Credit

A taxpayer sought assistance after the IRS audited a return and determined the taxpayer was not entitled to claim the Earned Income Tax Credit based on a sibling claimed as a dependent. The sibling had disabilities, lived with the taxpayer, and depended on the taxpayer for care following the death of their grandparent. Although the taxpayer submitted documentation supporting the sibling's eligibility due to disabilities, the IRS rejected the response and closed the examination. An LTC attorney stepped up to help and filed a Tax Court petition to challenge the determination. The IRS asked the Independent Office of Appeals to review the case, and the attorney's advocacy efforts resulted in the IRS conceding the case in full. As a result, the taxpayer received the refund, which provided essential financial support and stability for both siblings.

## Audit Reconsideration and Liability Reduction

Audit reconsideration is a powerful administrative tool that clinics use to reverse improperly denied expenses, deductions, and credits. In 2024, LITCs handled 658 audit reconsideration cases. Through audit reconsideration and other forms of relief, clinics successfully corrected or reduced over \$53 million in assessed tax liabilities. These efforts not only alleviated immediate financial burdens but also helped taxpayers regain compliance and avoid escalating enforcement actions.

## Status Issues

A taxpayer's filing status (single, head of household, married filing jointly, married filing separately, or qualifying widow(er)) affects their return filing status, their election to use the standard deduction or itemize, their eligibility for credits and deductions, and the amount of tax owed. Determining the correct filing status can be complicated, particularly when family circumstances change due to illness, separation, death, or caregiving responsibilities.

In 2024, LITCs assisted taxpayers in over 1,400 cases involving filing status, including 720 involving personal/dependency exemptions and over 2,500 non-filer cases. Clinics also assisted in 177 cases challenging a worker's classification, which involves questioning whether a worker is an employee or independent contractor.



### Surviving Spouse Wins Case With Low Income Taxpayer Clinic Help

A taxpayer came to an LTC shortly before a scheduled Tax Court trial after learning of a tax debt following the death of their spouse, who had suffered with dementia. Shortly before the passing of the spouse, a return preparer filed a return on behalf of the couple. The return reflected a filing status inconsistent with the taxpayer's prior filings, resulting in significantly higher tax liability.

Despite being in poor health, the taxpayer tried to address the issue by requesting innocent spouse relief and submitting an identity theft affidavit; the IRS denied both requests. After interviewing the taxpayer and reviewing the account history, the LTC attorney discovered a tax liability stemming from the deceased spouse's income. For the year in question, the taxpayer's filing status on the return was different from all their prior return filings, which resulted in the increased tax. During a settlement conference, the LTC attorney presented the facts and explained the taxpayer's circumstances. The IRS correctly conceded the case, resulting in a substantial reduction in the tax owed. This outcome allowed the taxpayer to resolve the remaining balance and move forward with peace of mind, knowing this matter was fully resolved.

## Innocent Spouse Relief

When married taxpayers opt to file using "married filing jointly" status, tax laws provide that both are responsible for the entire tax liability, a concept known as joint and several liability. Both continue to be liable for the debt even if they divorce and the final orders state otherwise. In certain circumstances, one spouse's actions may make it unfair to hold the other spouse fully responsible, providing relief from joint and several liability, referred to as innocent spouse relief. These cases can be tricky for taxpayers to navigate successfully when representing themselves. This difficulty may be compounded when domestic violence is involved.

In 2024, LITCs helped 546 taxpayers navigate the process to obtain innocent spouse relief. When the IRS denied the request for relief at the administrative level, clinics often helped taxpayers pursue their rights in Tax Court to litigate the issue and ensure a fair and just outcome.

## Representing Taxpayers in Court

Taxpayers have the right to challenge an IRS determination in court when they cannot resolve their disputes through administrative channels. For many low-income taxpayers, however, accessing the judicial system without representation is daunting. Court procedures, legal standards, and evidentiary requirements can be difficult to navigate, particularly for individuals already experiencing financial or personal hardship. LITCs play a critical role in ensuring that taxpayers can meaningfully exercise their right to be heard. Clinics represent taxpayers before the U.S. Tax Court and other federal courts, including U.S. district courts and, in limited cases, the U.S. Supreme Court.

In FY 2024, 80% of the cases filed in the Tax Court involved self-represented taxpayers, underscoring the ongoing need for accessible legal assistance.<sup>14</sup> Nearly 9% of all LTC cases worked in 2024 involved litigation, with the majority occurring in Tax Court. Without representation, taxpayers must navigate complex pre-trial requirements, including motions, memoranda, and stipulations. If a case proceeds to trial, they must navigate calling witnesses, presenting evidence, and conducting cross-examination – tasks that can be overwhelming without legal training. Recognizing these barriers, the Tax Court is committed to access to justice for all petitioners and informs self-represented (*pro se*) taxpayers about the availability of LTC assistance by including LTC contact information in multiple court mailings.

Through the Tax Court's Calendar Call Program, participating LITCs also provide consultations to *pro se* taxpayers at calendar call sessions. In many cities, the Tax Court relies on a local LTC clinician to coordinate services to taxpayers wanting assistance. In 2024, 124 clinics participated in the program, consulting with 549 self-represented taxpayers and provided representation to 1,059 taxpayers in Tax Court proceedings.



### Low Income Taxpayer Clinic Goes to Tax Court and Beyond for Hardworking Taxpayer

To earn additional income to support their family, a taxpayer and parent of several children worked a part-time job for two years. Unfortunately, the part-time employer did not provide proper tax documents and inadvertently omitted income from the taxpayer's returns. Consequently, the IRS proposed adjustments, resulting in a tax deficiency and penalties totaling thousands. The LTC petitioned the Tax Court on the taxpayer's behalf and worked closely with the individual to reconstruct records for the tax years in question. Through negotiations with IRS Counsel, the clinic provided supporting documents, reducing the tax liability by thousands. The reduced income also made the taxpayer eligible for significant refundable credits. The LTC did not stop there and helped the taxpayer file several missing federal and state tax returns and negotiate a manageable state payment plan. With all issues resolved, the taxpayer was able to move forward in compliance, with confidence and financial stability restored.

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## Training Students to Provide High Quality Representation Services

LITCs based at law schools, business schools, and accounting programs play a dual role: serving taxpayers while training the next generation of tax professionals. Under the supervision of qualified practitioners, students and recent graduates assist with all aspects of clinic casework. Students help determine taxpayer eligibility for services, research issues, gather information from taxpayers and the IRS, and develop a strategy for representation. They also assist with litigation tasks such as collecting and reviewing evidence, drafting motions and briefs, and participating in hearings and oral arguments. By working directly with taxpayers, students develop and hone their advocacy skills while fostering a commitment to community involvement and *pro bono* work. Some students go on to careers in public service, including roles within the IRS. Their clinic experience provides them with valuable insight into and understanding of the taxpayer's perspective, which informs more effective and compassionate tax administration.



### Student Attorneys Save the Day at Tax Court

An academic LTC assisted a Spanish-speaking taxpayer at the Tax Court in a case involving denied dependent credits. One student attorney provided interpretation services, allowing the case to proceed without delay. Another student interviewed the taxpayer who brought their dependents to court. The students negotiated with IRS Counsel, leveraging the testimony of the taxpayer and dependent children, which resulted in the allowance of the dependent credits and a substantial refund. This case highlights how student involvement can expand a clinic's capacity and help ensure a language barrier does not prevent taxpayers from accessing justice.

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# LITCs EDUCATE TAXPAYERS

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Taxpayers who LITCs serve often share a common trait – the desire to comply with tax return filing requirements and payment responsibilities. For many low-income and ESL taxpayers, tax problems arise not from willful noncompliance but from limited access to clear, reliable information and difficulty navigating an increasingly complex tax system. LITCs play a critical role in educating taxpayers about their rights and responsibilities, helping demystify tax concepts such as eligibility rules for refundable credits, recordkeeping requirements, and recognition and avoidance of tax scams. Education empowers taxpayers to make informed decisions and promotes tax compliance, the cornerstone of effective tax administration.

Taxpayers with limited English proficiency face additional barriers to finding understandable and reliable tax information. Many who have immigrated to the United States may come from countries with very different tax systems and may be unfamiliar with U.S. filing and payment obligations. These taxpayers are also particularly vulnerable to risks such as identity theft or return preparer misconduct from unscrupulous tax return preparers who steal or divert refunds and disappear long before their bad acts are discovered. All of these can have long-lasting financial consequences.

When LITCs educate taxpayers, they create an environment where participants can interact with the instructor and ask questions. Clinics distribute tax materials in many different languages and have staff, volunteers, and interpreter services available to conduct educational activities in languages spoken by the clinics' target audiences. IRS Publication 4134 reflects the wide range of languages in which LITCs offer services.

In addition to education, clinics conduct outreach to inform others about the availability of LITC services. They share information about the availability of TAS, VITA sites, and other resources for taxpayer assistance in their local communities. LITCs collaborate and work extensively with many community partners and stakeholders to conduct training and outreach for taxpayers.

In 2024, LITCs conducted over 20,000 educational activities to over 161,000 low-income and ESL taxpayers. Clinics provided over 450 additional educational sessions to over 13,000 staff members and volunteers at partner community groups, government agencies, and other organizations that assist low-income and ESL taxpayers. These efforts strengthened the LITCs' relationships and networks with community stakeholders, expanded the scope of their outreach and education efforts, and enabled other service providers to look at client issues holistically to address their tax issues. These networks and partnerships allow for mutual referrals to address the different needs of low-income and ESL individuals.



## **A Low Income Taxpayer Clinic Develops an Innovative New Tax Education Program**

A nonprofit organization with a nationwide presence received LITC funding to develop a federal tax e-learning curriculum for low-income and ESL taxpayers. The curriculum, offered online in English and Spanish, features visual layouts with module navigation and interactive elements that help provide a clear structure for the taxpayer's learning journey as well as improve engagement and accessibility. The core content covers topics such as federal tax filing responsibilities and the availability of certain tax credits. Peer LITC practitioners are testing and reviewing the program to help identify areas for improvement in both content and user experience. Once completed, financial wellness coaches at partner organizations across the country will offer the program and help inform thousands of taxpayers. This e-learning resource is just one component of the LITC's tax education strategy.

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# LITCs ADVOCATE FOR TAXPAYERS

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The third prong of the LITC mission is advocacy. LITCs are uniquely positioned to identify emerging systemic issues or trends in tax administration that impact their taxpayer clients based on firsthand experience. LITCs see how IRS policies and procedures affect individual taxpayers and entire populations. LITCs also network with one another, which allows clinicians to gain a broader perspective on taxpayers in other areas experiencing similar problems.

LITCs are encouraged to share what they have learned to help improve service delivery by the IRS and the broader practitioner community. Clinicians share this knowledge in many ways, including developing resource materials and providing training to other practitioners. The knowledge they share is not limited to substantive tax expertise; it also involves removing barriers and improving outcomes by changing the way LITCs deliver service.

Advocacy efforts often require sustained effort. Raising awareness and building understanding take time and effort. One organization or groups of organizations can undertake advocacy efforts. LITCs support advocacy through many channels, including organizing and leading networking groups and participating in clinician listservs and other practitioner events to discuss emerging issues or ongoing problems.

When the IRS seeks public comment on IRS proposed administrative rules, LITCs often respond individually or in collaboration with the *Pro Bono* Tax Clinic Committee. They advocate through the comments they provide to help ensure IRS rules and procedures are fair and equitable for taxpayer populations who may not have the knowledge or resources to advocate for their own interests.

LITCs successfully address systemic issues administratively within the IRS and through the cases they litigate in the Tax Court and other federal courts. By challenging problematic interpretations of tax law or administrative practices, clinics can achieve outcomes that benefit individual taxpayers, similarly situated taxpayers nationwide, and the related impact under the tax laws in administrative processes and future litigation.



## A Low Income Taxpayer Clinic's Advocacy in Action

In 2024, an academic clinic litigated a case in the U.S. Court of Appeals for the Second Circuit on behalf of a taxpayer who missed a filing deadline in the Tax Court. The LITC argued that equitable tolling should apply to extend the timeframe to file the case in Tax Court, thus allowing the taxpayer's case to proceed. The outcome of this case may impact many low-income taxpayers; if the taxpayer wins, the Tax Court will be able to consider more cases for taxpayers who had a good reason for missing the filing deadline.

This academic clinic also reported submitting comments on proposed amendments to the Tax Court Rules of Practice and Procedures, highlighting opportunities to incorporate recent legal developments and further clarify taxpayer rights in its various rules. These efforts demonstrate how LITC advocacy helps shape policies that promote fairness and access to justice.

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# LITC PROGRAM OFFICE RESPONSIBILITIES

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The LITC Program Office manages and administers the LITC grant program to ensure that clinics use federal funds appropriately and operate in accordance with all applicable statutory, regulatory, and public policy requirements. Core responsibilities include administering the award and disbursing grant funds, providing guidance and assistance to prospective applicants and grant recipients, and overseeing and monitoring clinic performance.

Each year, the Program Office revises and issues Publication 3319, Low Income Taxpayer Clinics Grant Application Package and Guidelines, which provides clear instructions for applicants and program guidance. Additionally, the program updates Publication 4134, Low Income Taxpayer Clinic List, annually to ensure accurate public information is available about funded clinics. Program staff review all grant applications, analyze performance data from clinic reports, and make funding recommendations to the National Taxpayer Advocate. They analyze performance data from progress reports submitted by LITCs to identify clinic support needs, performance trends, and best practices. This data informs program involvement and activities, contributes to the program's annual report, and supports responses to information requests from TAS and IRS.

To empower the LITCs in their mission and support what they need to succeed, the Program Office provides guidance and technical assistance to current grant recipients and prospective applicants. The office maintains the LITC Toolkit, a website used to share news, guidance, best practices, and resources with clinics, and organize and host the Annual LITC Grantee Conference, which provides training to LITC staff and fosters relationships between clinicians. Program Office staff also organize multiple training opportunities for clinics throughout the year, are responsible for issuing special appearance authorizations that permit students and law graduates to represent taxpayers before the IRS, and coordinate access to e-Services products offered by the IRS.

Oversight is a key component of the Program Office's responsibilities. This includes reviewing clinic budgets and financial reports to ensure clinics properly expend federal funds and properly source, spend, and value matching funds. The Program Office staff ensures the clinics follow the eligibility requirements, and they conduct site assistance visits to interview clinic personnel, observe facilities, review procedures and internal controls, corroborate report information, and evaluate operations. The Program Office also coordinates the civil rights pre-award compliance reviews with the IRS and takes steps to ensure all clinics are following all federal tax and other obligations. Through these oversight efforts, the Program Office ensures clinics maintain transparency, accountability, and compliance with all applicable laws and policies.

In 2024, the Program Office reviewed its oversight procedures and began the process of revising the progress reporting forms to help reduce administrative burden on the LITCs and improve the efficiency of the program. The office started development of a new comprehensive grants management system and successfully hosted the Annual LITC Grantee Conference in person at a new location.

# CONCLUSION

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The LITC Program Office extends its sincere gratitude to members of Congress for their continued support of the LITC Program. Increased funding and higher award caps have enabled clinics to expand their reach and provide essential services to taxpayers who might otherwise have nowhere to turn.

We also recognize the invaluable contributions of the LITC clinicians, students, law graduates, and volunteers whose dedication and compassion transformed the lives of thousands of taxpayers in 2024. Through representation, education, and advocacy, your work inspires and changes lives every day, restores financial stability, and strengthens trust in the tax system.

As we look ahead, the LITC Program remains committed to addressing emerging challenges and embracing new opportunities to improve and collaborate with community partners to find innovative ways to reduce barriers to service. Together, we will continue working to ensure that every taxpayer, regardless of income, language, or circumstance, has access to justice within the tax system.

Finally, we extend our heartfelt gratitude to the vendors who generously provide complimentary software and online tools that are essential to the work of LITCs.<sup>15</sup> Your support equips clinics with the technology and resources needed to serve taxpayers effectively, efficiently, and with care. By removing financial barriers and expanding access to high quality tools, you play a meaningful role in strengthening taxpayer advocacy and access to justice.



**We thank the following organizations for their continued partnership and generosity:**

- ◆ **Bloomberg**
- ◆ **Blue J Legal, Inc.**
- ◆ **Drake Software – TaxAct Professional**
- ◆ **Tax Analysts**
- ◆ **Tax Help Software**

# ENDNOTES

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- 1 This report uses gender neutral pronouns in case summaries and examples to protect the anonymity of the parties involved.
- 2 Pub. L. No. 105-206, § 3601, 112 Stat. 685, 774 (1998).
- 3 IRC § 7526.
- 4 See Consolidated Appropriations Act, 2023, Pub. L. No. 117-328, Div. E, 136 Stat. 4459, 4655-56 (2022); Further Consolidated Appropriations Act, 2024, Pub. L. No. 118-47, Div. B, 138 Stat. 27, 526 (2024). Removing the per-clinic cap would provide TAS flexibility in allocating appropriated funds between clinics but would not impact the total annual appropriated funds.
- 5 See National Taxpayer Advocate 2025 Purple Book, *Compilation of Legislative Recommendations to Strengthen Taxpayer Rights and Improve Tax Administration* 155-157 (Legislative Recommendation: Enable the Low Income Taxpayer Clinic Program to Assist More Taxpayers in Controversies With the IRS), [https://www.taxpayeradvocate.irs.gov/wp-content/uploads/2024/12/ARC24\\_PurpleBook\\_08\\_MiscRecs\\_65.pdf](https://www.taxpayeradvocate.irs.gov/wp-content/uploads/2024/12/ARC24_PurpleBook_08_MiscRecs_65.pdf).
- 6 IRC § 7803(a)(3)(I).
- 7 See IRC § 7803(a)(3)(C), (D), (E).
- 8 See IRC § 7803(a)(3)(A).
- 9 See IRC § 7803(a)(3)(J).
- 10 Taxpayer First Act, Pub. L. No. 116-25, § 1402, 133 Stat. 981, 997 (2019).
- 11 VITA sites offer free tax help to taxpayers who need assistance preparing their own tax returns, including people who generally make \$67,000 or less, persons with disabilities, and limited English-speaking taxpayers.
- 12 Taxpayer First Act, Pub. L. No. 116-25, § 1401, 133 Stat. 981, 993 (2019).
- 13 See IRS Pub. 3319, 2026 LITC Grant Application Package and Guidelines, 6 (May 2025), <https://www.irs.gov/pub/irs-pdf/p3319.pdf>.
- 14 United States Tax Court Congressional Budget Justification, FY 2026 27 (May 1, 2025), [https://ustaxcourt.gov/files/documents/FY\\_2026\\_Congressional\\_Budget\\_Justification.pdf](https://ustaxcourt.gov/files/documents/FY_2026_Congressional_Budget_Justification.pdf).
- 15 Thanking these vendors for their donations to the LITCs does not constitute an endorsement of the vendors or their services.

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